

STRIVE
FOR LESS THAN

5 DAYS ABSENT



GRPS ATTENDANCE PLAYBOOK



**GRAND RAPIDS PUBLIC SCHOOLS
BOARD OF EDUCATION**

This playbook was developed with the invaluable support and guidance of the GRPS Board of Education. Their steadfast commitment to fostering scholar success and ensuring equitable access to quality education has been instrumental in shaping the strategies and resources contained within this guide. We extend our deepest gratitude for their leadership and dedication to improving attendance outcomes for all scholars.

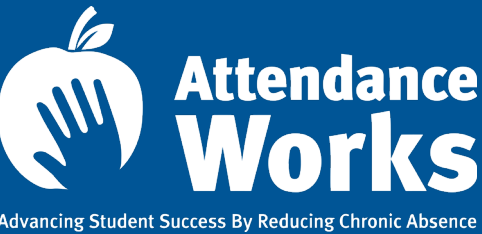


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UNDERSTANDING THE IMPORTANCE OF ATTENDANCE



WHY DOES ATTENDANCE MATTER?

Research shows that chronic absence—missing 10 percent of the school year, whether excused or unexcused—can hinder elementary students' reading skills by third grade and increase the likelihood of dropout for older students.¹ Moreover, absenteeism can become a habit; those who are chronically absent in elementary school often continue the pattern in middle and high school.

Tackling GRPS absenteeism is crucial for closing the achievement gap. When scholars miss school, it disrupts the entire class's progress; widespread absenteeism makes it harder for teachers to teach and students to learn.

¹ Chang, Hedy & Romero, Mariajose, "Present, Engaged & Accounted For: The Critical Importance of Addressing Chronic Absence in the Early Grades," National Center for Children in Poverty: NY, NY, September 2008. add in Applied Research brief



MISLEADING METRICS

 **READ MORE:**
[Chronic Absence & Truancy](#)

Average Daily Attendance (ADA) – A metric used in state and federal reporting, calculated by dividing a school’s total attendance by its total instructional days. However, since ADA doesn’t account for individual scholars’ repeated absences, it can obscure the true extent and impact of absenteeism.

Truancy – 10 Unexcused absences in a school year

CATEGORIES OF CHRONIC ABSENTEEISM

Chronic Absenteeism – Missing 10% or more days of school; includes excused, unexcused absences and suspensions

ABSENTEEISM CATEGORY	PERCENT OF DAYS	NUMBER OF DAYS
SATISFACTORY	Less than 5%	Less than 9
AT RISK	5%–9.9%	9 to 18
MODERATE CHRONIC	10%–19.9%	18 to 35
SEVERE CHRONIC	More than 20%	More than 35

CHRONIC ABSENCE IS SOLVABLE



BARRIERS

- Unmet basic needs
- High suspension rates
- Trauma

AVERSION

- Poor school climate
- Academic struggles
- Parents' negative school experience

DISENGAGEMENT

- Lack of engaging instruction
- No meaningful relationships with adults in school

MISCONCEPTIONS

- Absences only a problem if they're unexcused
- Attendance only matters in later grades



GRPS AND ATTENDANCE WORKS STRATEGIC PLAN

Chronic absence stems from the ongoing challenges of poverty and unequal access to learning opportunities. It disproportionately impacts Latino and Black students, exacerbating academic disparities.² Additionally, chronic absence is both a cause and a consequence of harsh disciplinary actions; for instance, absenteeism in kindergarten can predict middle school suspensions.

GRPS Strategic Themes

1. Meet Holistic Scholar Needs
2. Optimize and Value All School Options
3. Ensure Equitable Access and Outcomes
4. Enhance Curriculum and Program Opportunities
5. Cultivate an Engaged, Impactful, More Diverse Workforce
6. Create a Culture of Trust, Collaboration, and Stewardship



 **READ MORE:**
[Objectives of
Chronic Absence
& Attendance and
their Connection
to GRPS Strategic
Themes](#)

Improving attendance and reducing Chronic Absence is relevant to each GRPS Strategic Theme.

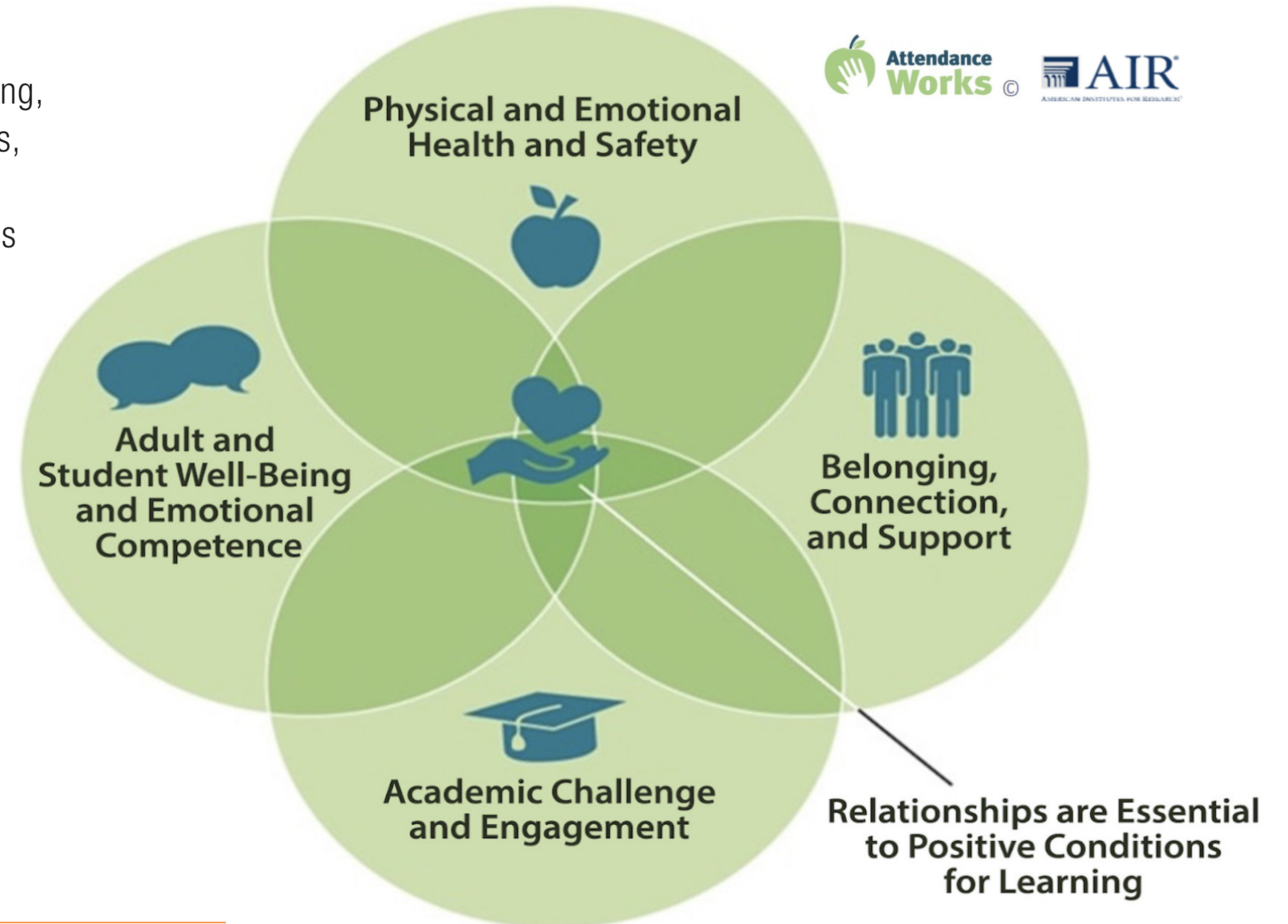
² Using *Chronic Absence to Map Interrupted Schooling, Instructional Loss and Educational Inequity: Insights from School Year 2017-18 Data*, by Attendance Works and the Everyone Graduates Center, February 2021.



POSITIVE CONDITIONS FOR LEARNING

[READ MORE:
Using Chronic Absence
Data to Improve
Positive Conditions
for Learning](#)

Reducing chronic absence goes hand in hand with cultivating positive conditions for learning. When schools provide engaging, supportive, welcoming and culturally responsive environments, families are inclined to help their children get to school, and students are motivated to attend, even when there are hurdles to getting there. Likewise, when students attend class consistently, positive conditions for learning — from supportive relationships with teachers to substantive, meaningful educational experiences — are more likely to occur.³



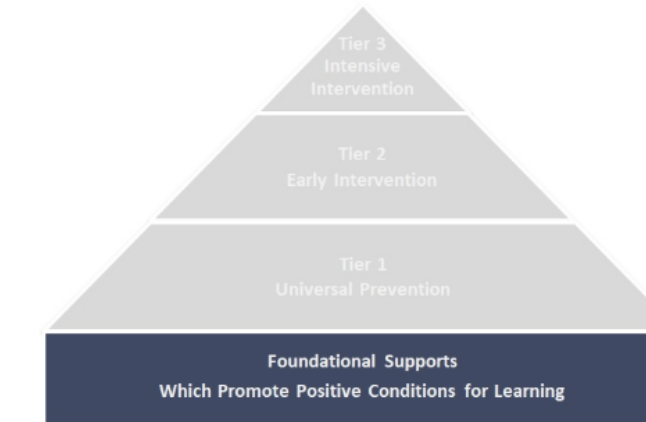
³ Hedy N. Chang, David Osher, Mara Schanfield, Jane Sundius and Lauren Bauer, *Using Chronic Absence Data to Improve Positive Conditions for Learning*, Attendance Works and American Institutes for Research (AIR), September 2019.



EXPANDING ON POSITIVE CONDITIONS FOR LEARNING

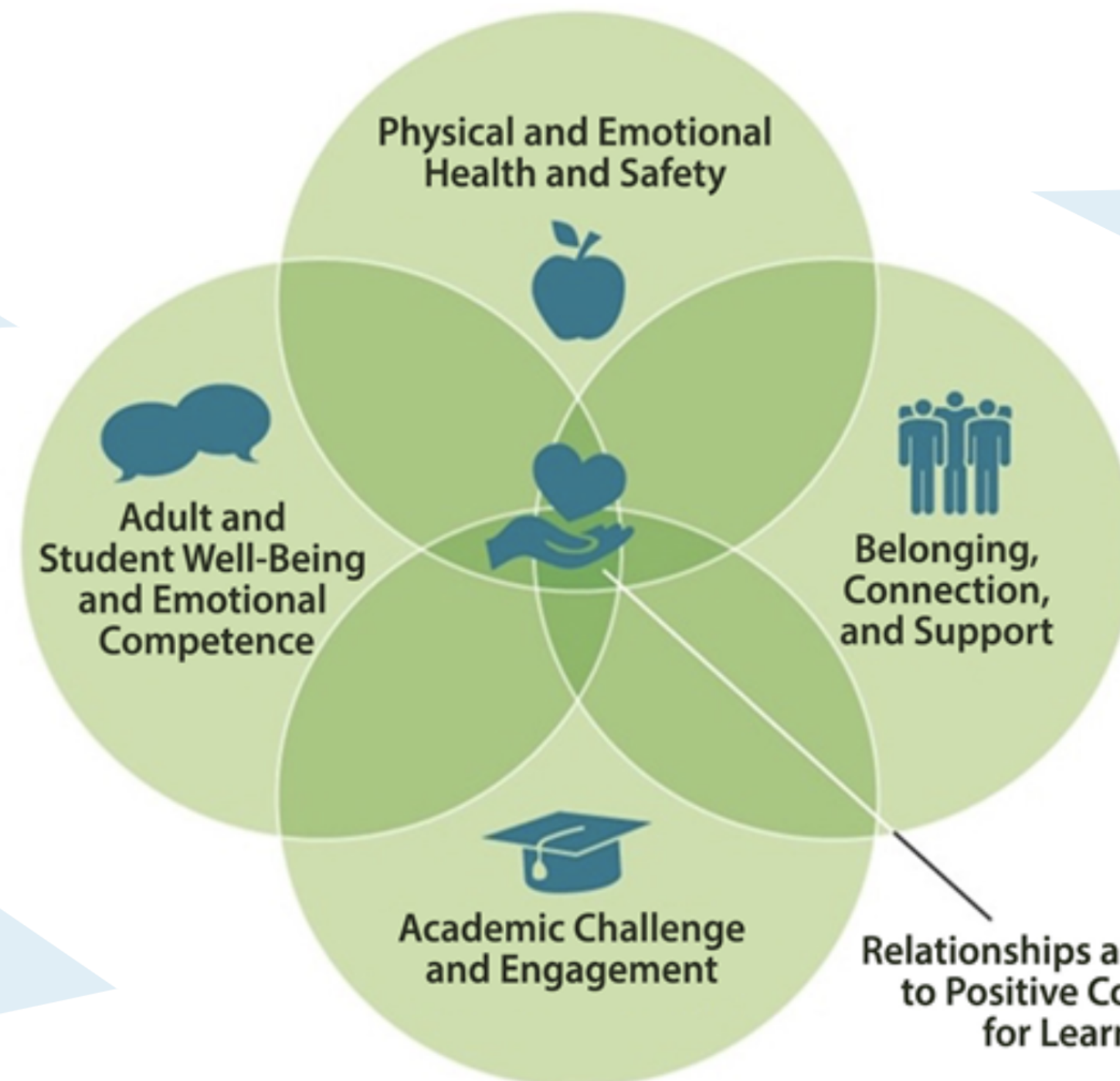
 **READ MORE:**
[Positives Conditions
For Learning
Strategies & Barriers](#)

Positive Conditions for Learning Lead to Students Being Engaged and Attending Regularly



- Restorative check-ins
- Access to health care & mental health supports
- Trauma-informed practice
- Staff self-care (Opportunity Thrive)

- Access to tech & internet
- Learning supports (differentiation)
- Project-based learning
- Credit recovery opportunities (E2020)
- Internships/community service
- Alternative scheduling options ("zero hour" or "7th hour", 2nd shift)



- Healthy learning environments
- Welcoming, safe school climate
- Access to food & other basic needs
- Restorative circles

- Active student & family engagement
- Advisory class
- SEL
- Enrichment & clubs
- Positive peer connections



www.attendanceworks.org



STRIVE FOR LESS THAN 5

“Strive for Less than 5” refers to the goal of scholars missing less than five days of school.

Schools should have a building level challenge between each grade level to see who has the best attendance each month.

BACKGROUND

In 2006, six GRPS schools participated in a pilot program with Kent School Services Network (KSSN). The primary goal of the program was to improve attendance. This was the first programmatic focus on attendance at GRPS and was limited to those six schools. A district-wide effort, “Make Every Day Count” was adopted in the fall of 2013. A three-domain approach, coordinating planning across the district, school, and community levels was undertaken. The following year, with a few adjustments, the program was reintroduced as “Challenge 5,” with the tagline “Strive for Less than 5” referring to the goal of less than five days of missed school. Today, the program is known simply as “Strive for Less than 5”.

Description	Sample	Size	Quantity
Double sided yard sign		18"x24"	_____
Roll of stickers (roll of 500)		2"x2"	_____
Magnets		3.5"x2"	____ English ____ Spanish
Bumper Stickers		10"x3.5"	____ English ____ Spanish
Hanging banners 2 maximum		96"x48"	____ English ____ Spanish
Razor fish flag 1 maximum		8.5' tall, double sided	____ English ____ Spanish

ORDER FORM: [Order Strive For Less Than Five Merchandise](#)



UNIVERSAL & PROACTIVE STRATEGIES





UNIVERSAL STRATEGIES

 **READ MORE:**
[Handouts for Families](#)

1. Recognize Attendance – Acknowledge good and improved attendance with incentives like certificates, extra recess, or homework passes. Avoid emphasizing perfect attendance to include those who need improvement.

 **READ MORE:**
[Create a Welcoming Environment that Engages Students and Families](#)

2. Engage Students and Parents – Foster a welcoming environment that builds positive relationships with families. Promote a culture of safety, respect, and responsibility, letting scholars know they are missed when absent. Educate families on the impact of absences on their children's futures.

 **READ MORE:**
[Develop Staff Capacity to Adopt Effective Attendance Practice](#)

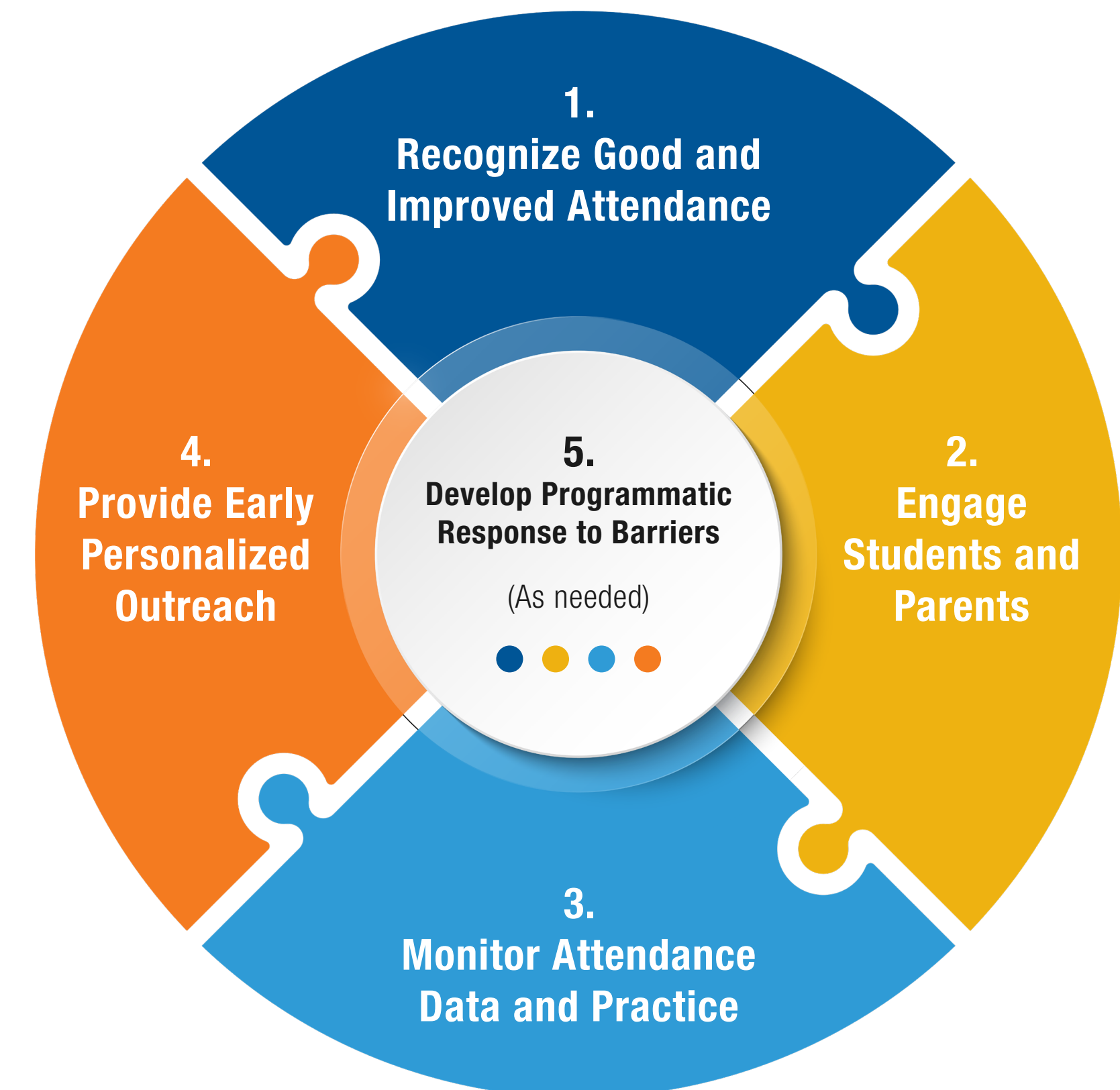
3. Monitor Attendance Data – Create a team to track attendance data and support chronically absent scholars. Use existing district data to identify scholars missing 10% or more of the school year and monitor trends over time.

 **READ MORE:**
[The Power of Positive Connections Toolkit](#)

4. Personalized Early Outreach – Identify families needing support through data analysis and connect with scholars who are missing school. Address barriers like hunger, healthcare access, or transportation and prepare proactive resources for those likely to need them.

 **READ MORE:**
[Visit the Parent University website](#)

5. Programmatic Response to Barriers – Initiate programs like Parent University to engage families and reduce chronic absenteeism. This program empowers parents to advocate for their children's success and supports the other strategies.



Source: Attendance Works

 **READ MORE:** [Tiered Absence Intervention Strategies](#)



SOCIAL & EMOTIONAL LEARNING

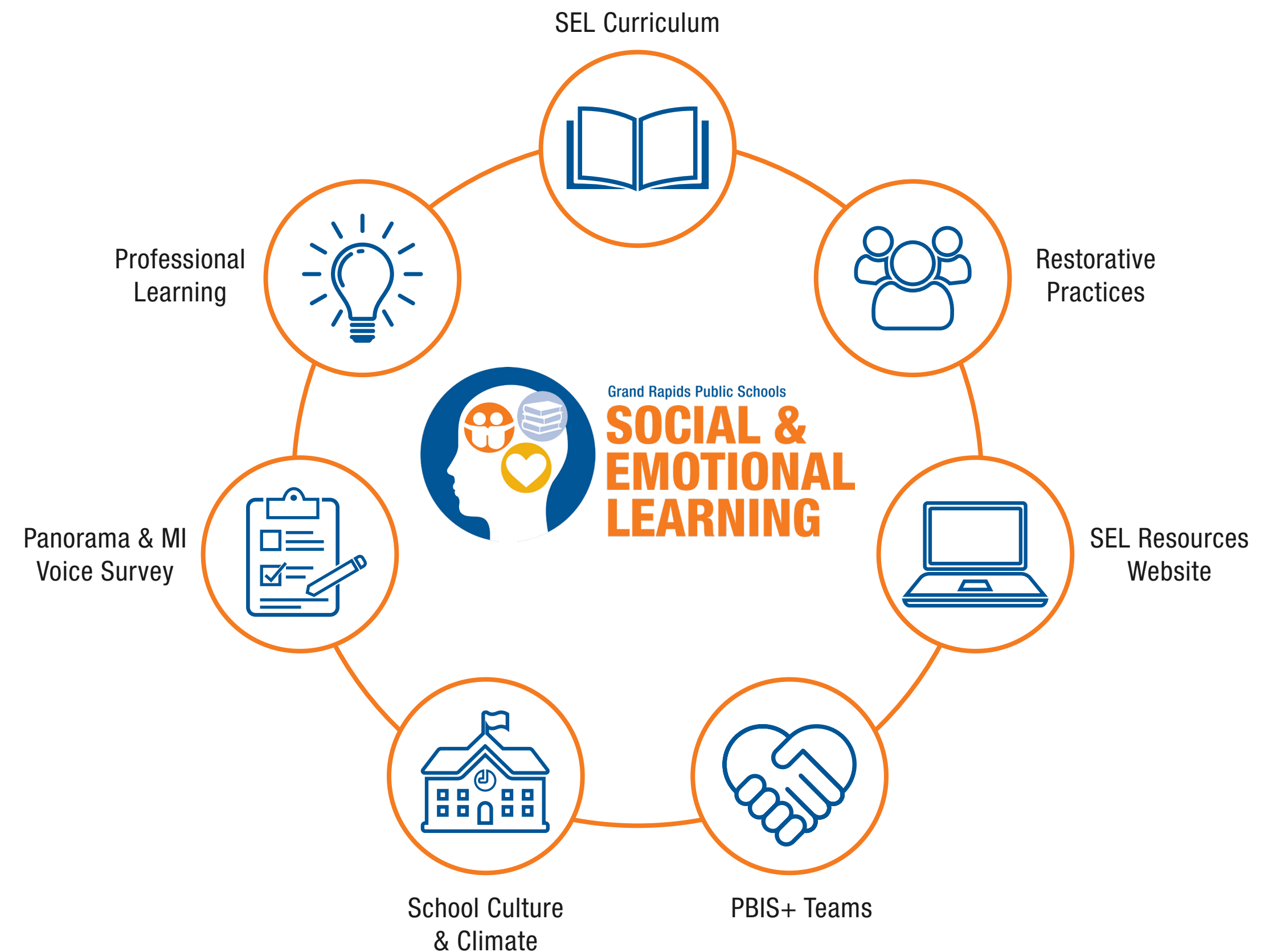
[READ MORE:](#)
[Visit the Social
Emotional Learning
Webpage](#)

What is Social & Emotional Learning?

Our community is dedicated to educating the whole child. This includes focusing on social and emotional learning (SEL) for scholars and adults by explicitly teaching and modeling attitudes and skills necessary to:

- Recognize and manage their emotions
- Demonstrate caring and concern for others
- Establish positive relationships
- Make responsible decisions
- Constructively handle challenging social situations

The GRPS SEL webpage is full of resources that can be useful for parents, scholars, and educators. The link below takes you to a resources page that provides SEL best practices and ideas for supporting scholars and families inside and outside the classroom.





SEL AND ATTENDANCE

[READ MORE:
The CASEL 5
Framework](#)

SEL plays a crucial role in addressing chronic absenteeism by fostering a supportive school environment that promotes scholar engagement and well-being. When scholars develop skills in self-regulation, relationship-building, and emotional awareness, they are more likely to feel connected to their school community.

This connection can reduce feelings of isolation or disengagement, which are often contributing factors to absenteeism. Additionally, SEL programs can help scholars navigate personal challenges and improve their resilience, ultimately encouraging consistent attendance and participation in their education.





RESTORATIVE PRACTICES

Restorative practices offer an intentional and respectful approach to addressing behavioral issues in schools, prioritizing relationship-building and community repair. Restorative Practices utilizes techniques such as:

- *Proactive Circles*
- *Shared Agreements*
- *Community Building Circles*

These prevent relationship damaging incidents from happening and repairing them if they do. Implementation of Restorative Practices in schools help improve the five main social and emotional learning skills:

1. Self-Awareness
2. Self-Management
3. Relationships Skills
4. Social Awareness
5. Responsible Decision Making

Together, Social and Emotional Learning and Restorative Practices are used to improve school climate by strengthening scholar-to-scholar, staff-to-staff and scholar-to-staff relationships.





MULTIPLE TIERED SYSTEM OF SUPPORTS (MTSS)

 **READ MORE:**
[What is MTSS?](#)

A multi-tiered system of support (MTSS) offers a comprehensive framework for K-12 educators and leaders to enhance scholar learning. It enables them to:

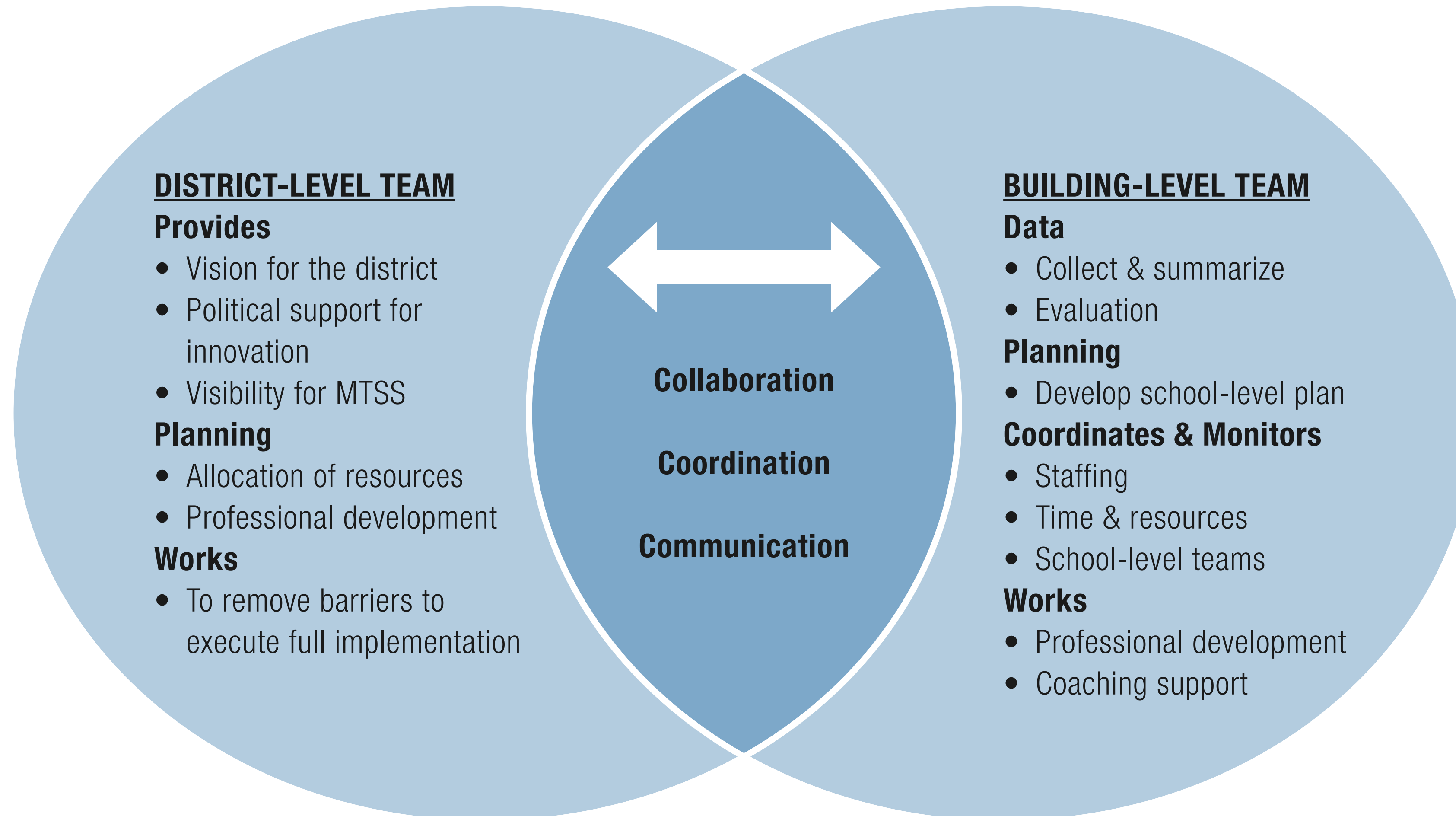
- Remove systemic barriers to learning
- Implement evidence-based practices for grade-level achievement
- Make data-driven decisions for targeted interventions

MTSS fosters consistency across districts, ensuring all scholars receive equitable support. Educators, counselors, and administrators collaborate towards a shared goal of creating a positive learning environment tailored to every scholar's developmental needs. By regularly analyzing data, they can address scholar needs proactively and intervene before larger challenges emerge.



DISTRICT–BUILDING PARTNERSHIP FOR EFFECTIVE MTSS

 **READ MORE:**
[Quick Guide for
Multi-Tiered System
of Supports: Building
Level](#)





MULTI-SYSTEMS OF SUPPORT (MTSS) FRAMEWORK

 **READ MORE:**
[MTSS Definitions & References](#)

ACADEMICS	ATTENDANCE	MENTAL HEALTH	PBIS W/ SEL INTEGRATION	LEVELS OF SUPPORT
Individualized Education Plan Student Success Team Intensive Reading or Math Interventions Alternative Learning Environment	Student Success Team Legal interventions (as a last resort) Barriers (e.g. housing, transportation, etc.)	Individual therapy & Related task e.g. (play therapy, coping skills) Coordination with primary care providers, psychiatry, and/or outside counseling as needed.	Student Success Team Referral for mental health and/or KSSN services Wraparound Services (i.e. Family Outreach Center, Arbor Circle) Restorative Practices (Re-entry Circle)	Tier 3 Intensive (frequent and targeted) Interventions/Instruction and Comprehensive Evaluation 1-5%
Small group instruction Tutoring Push in/out	Restorative Practices (Conferencing) Individualize Attendance Plan Expanding Learning Opportunities	Group Therapy & Related task Transforming Research into Action to Improve the Lives of Students (TRAILS) to Wellness SEL Curriculum (Cognitive behavior therapy & mindfulness)	Check-in/Check-out Alternatives to suspension 1:1 Community Partnership Mentoring (i.e. Kids Hope, Affinity Mentoring) Restorative Practices (Conferencing)	Tier 2 Targeted/Strategic Interventions/Instruction 10-15%
Universal Screening Data-Driven Decision Making Differentiation	Recognize good and improved attendance Connection to a caring adult Attendance Team	Mental Health Resources Mental Health Awareness Month – May	Teaching schoolwide expectations and procedures through SEL skills Restorative Practices (Community Building) Schoolwide celebrations & community events (i.e. Assemblies, carnivals) Evidence-based explicit SEL curriculum	Tier 1 High-Quality Classroom Instruction, Screening, and Classroom Intervention Strategies 80-90%



HEALTH & WELLNESS CONNECTION TO ATTENDANCE



HEALTH AND ATTENDANCE

School nurses play a key role in GRPS academic success. School nursing, a specialized practice of nursing, protects and promotes scholar health, facilitates optimal development, and advances academic success.

In regards to chronic health barriers and attendance, chronic diseases or lack of health/dental care is an impeding barrier on GRPS scholar attendance. Taking action to address health-related chronic absenteeism can have a powerful impact on scholars academic success and well-being. Below are resources to help address health-related barriers within schools:

- A [toolkit](#) developed by the Healthy Schools Campaign
- [Healthy and ready to learn](#) is a resource-rich website from the Children's Health Fund designed to help health-related barriers to attendance
- Attendance Works provides [Health handouts](#) that help districts communicate clearly and often with families to address fears about when to send a child to school after an illness or how they can handle a scholar who may have anxiety.

WHEN SHOULD A SCHOLAR STAY HOME FROM SCHOOL DUE TO ILLNESS?

A scholar should remain home from school if they have any of these symptoms:

- **Fever 100.4 or higher or chills**
- **Sore throat**
- **New cough or change in cough**
- **Diarrhea and/ or vomiting**
- **Shortness of breath or wheezing**
- **Sores/ rash on skin with pus or liquid drainage**

Scholars being sick is often more prevalent in the wintertime. It is important to communicate with parents and caregivers by offering support to overcome these challenges. [In these tips](#) provided by Attendance Works, you can read about how to support attendance, engagement and learning in the winter months.



MENTAL HEALTH AND ATTENDANCE

 **READ MORE:**
[Tap Into Student
Voice for Student
Success](#)

Scholar voice is important in creating a healthy and social environment at GRPS. Scholars should be able to express themselves by learning critical social and emotional skills, alongside learning academics. This includes managing mental health challenges and building emotional intelligence skills that are “crucial for reducing bullying and risky behaviors, working with others, overcoming obstacles, and setting and achieving goals. Allowing students to weigh in on the decisions made on their behalf means that the school district’s actions will have more support and be easier to implement. Students will feel heard, and leaders will get a prioritized list of their students’ needs.”⁴

 **READ MORE:**
[Student Voice
Schoolwide
Self-Assessment](#)

This self-assessment tool is intended to support educators and students in assessing student voice practices (SVPs) in their schools and identifying ways to better incorporate student voice into school decision-making. This self-assessment tool serves the following purposes⁵:

- To formalize the concepts of SVPs in your school
- To be used as a low-stake peer/self-assessment tool for strengthening SVPs in your school, and
- To be used as a formative or summative evaluation tool for assessing the structures and operationalization of SVPs in your school

⁴ Mathias, S. (2023, July 7). 5 Ways Student Voice Enhances Education Quality. ThoughtExchange. Retrieved December 13, 2024, from <https://thoughtexchange.com/blog/student-voice-enhances-edu-quality/>

⁵ Holquist, S., Rodriguez, Y. & O’Toole, D. (2023). *Schoolwide Student Voice Self-Assessment Tool*. Minneapolis, MN: Child Trends.



WHY FOCUS ON MENTAL HEALTH?

 **READ MORE:**
[GRPS School Based
Mental Health
Services](#)

Based on research conducted by [National Alliance on Mental Illness \(NAMI\)](#), mentally healthy students are more likely to go to school ready to learn, actively engage in school activities, have supportive and caring connections with adults and young people, use appropriate problem-solving skills, have non aggressive behaviors, and add to positive school culture.

Children and youth spend the majority of their time in school. Which means schools play an increasingly critical role in supporting these students and providing a safe, non-stigmatizing, and supportive natural environment in which children, youth, and families have access to prevention, early intervention, and treatment through school-based mental health programs.⁶

Did you know?

 **READ MORE:**
[Visit the Our Mental
Health Collective
website](#)

Our Mental Health Collective is a local Mental Health Provider that offers culturally responsive and affirming mental health care resources for Black, African, Asian, Indigenous, Latine and other marginalized communities and professionals.

⁶ Mental health in schools. NAMI. (2024, June 27).
<https://www.nami.org/advocacy/policy-priorities/improving-health/mental-health-in-schools/#:~:text=School%2Dbased%20mental%20health%20services,effective%20treatments%2C%20and%20equitable%20access>.





ENGAGING FAMILIES & COMMUNITIES



FAMILY & COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT (F.A.C.E.)

The Family & Community Engagement (F.A.C.E.) department supports parents, guardians, and community stakeholders by building a cooperative link between home, school, and the community.

The FACE plan has four goals:

1. Building capacity of staff and families to work effectively as partners
2. Developing two-way communication between staff and parents
3. Creating joint decision-making opportunities for staff and parents
4. Ensuring equitable distribution of resources for family engagement



Did you know?

 **READ MORE:**
[Visit the Findhelp website](#)

Findhelp is a website created to help people find free or reduced-cost resources like food, housing, financial assistance, health care, and more. Findhelp supports students and staff at education institutions around the country.





EXPANDING ON FACE

FACE office pursues these goals two ways:

Fostering opportunities to build school-based community

- Joining the school's parent organization (PTCC, etc.)
- Attending parenting workshops through Parent University (parents.grps.org)
- Volunteering in classrooms/after school activities
- Tutoring children in specific content areas
- Attending open houses and parent teacher conferences on a regular basis
- Contacting teachers/counselors by phone or mail to discuss status of your child
- Reading all communication sent home from the school
- Joining specialized groups within the school that promote specific short term projects (beautification of school grounds, fundraisers, chaperone for different events, etc.)



 **READ MORE:**
[Visit the Parent University website](#)

 **READ MORE:**
[Visit the Volunteer webpage at grps.org](#)

Supporting the agency of families with instruction, engagement, and resources

- | | | |
|--|---|----------------------------|
| • Math night | • M-STEP night | • After school clubs |
| • Parent Action Leader (PALs) | • Coffee with the principal | • Community bulletin board |
| • Family science fair/night | • PreK Open House | |
| • Summer make-and-take (reinforcement activities for summer) | • Family board game series (game night) | |
| | • School & Classroom newsletters | |

 **READ MORE:**
[View an excerpt about F.A.C.E. from GRPS Title 1 Handbook](#)

The background is a photograph of a classroom, dimly lit and overlaid with a semi-transparent blue filter. Several rows of wooden desks and black chairs are visible, arranged in a typical classroom layout. At the front of the room, there are two whiteboards and a projector mounted on the ceiling. The floor has a patterned tile design. On the left side of the image, there are several vertical bars of varying heights and shades of blue and white, creating a modern, data-oriented aesthetic.

UTILIZING DATA & ANALYTICS



SYNERGY ANALYTICS

 **READ MORE:**
[Synergy Analytics User Guide](#)

Synergy is a scholar information system (SIS) used by GRPS for managing scholar data, including attendance, grades, and other performance metrics. It provides a centralized platform for administrators, teachers, and parents to monitor and support student progress. Synergy’s analytics is a valuable tool for school principals focused on improving attendance and overall scholar success.

 **READ MORE:**
[GRPS Synergy Analytics Dashboard Catalog](#)

The best way to identify scholars with chronic absence is to use the attendance data already collected and compiled in the district. By using this data you can examine which and how many scholars are missing 10% or more of the school year. This data lets you monitor trends over time by grade and various subgroups.

The Synergy Analytics User Guide will enable you to navigate the new Synergy Analytics dashboards, through which you can access live data pertaining to attendance and suspensions at the district or school-level.

COMMONLY USED SYNERGY REPORTS		
Chronic Absenteeism	Daily Attendance Buildings	Period Attendance Buildings
U-CHRON 027 Chronic Student Detail by School A list of students and their current Chronic Absenteeism Status	ATD201 Daily Attendance Profile An individual student report showing all attendance during a specified time period	ATP201 Period Student Attendance Profile An individual student report showing all attendance by period during a specified time period
U-CHRON 028 Cumulative Chronic Absenteeism Status A count of students in Chronic Absenteeism Categories grouped into their currently enrolled building.	ATD401 Daily Student Absences Totals A list of students with the number of absences during a specified time period	U-CHRON 031 Chronic DATT Chronic Absenteeism School & District Attendance Tracking Tool
	ATD-402 Daily Student Absence Totals A total of scholar absences by reason code	ATP-402 Period Student Absence Totals A total of scholar absences by reason code

 **READ MORE:** [Additional Attendance Synergy Reports](#)



SEL DATA: PANORAMA

 **READ MORE:**
[Responding to
Panorama Survey
Results](#)

Panorama Education is a platform used to help identify interventions and target supports needed for scholars to thrive. GRPS scholars take this survey twice a year while staff and caregivers take this once a year. These surveys measure metrics of sense of belonging, self-efficacy, positive and challenging feelings.

INTERVENTIONS FOR COMBATING CHRONIC ABSENTEEISM

 **READ MORE:**
[Playlist for
Interventions for
Combating
Chronic Absenteeism
Spreadsheet](#)

This curated collection of evidence-based and research-based intervention strategies is designed to help schools and districts combat chronic absenteeism. Follow the instructions in the Playlist for Interventions for Combating Chronic Absenteeism to explore these resources and equip educators with resources from Panorama’s Playbook for supporting strong attendance.

PANORAMA’S PLAYBOOK

As part of our partnership with Panorama, GRPS staff has access to Playbook, Panorama’s professional learning library that connects educators with hundreds of instructional resources and interventions across academics, behavior, and life skills to support students holistically and within an MTSS/RTI framework. Below is an example of what you see when filtering to Middle School SEL strategies:

Four-Stage Rocket

Panorama Education

Average rating: 5.0/5.0 (6 votes)

This strategy is designed to prepare students for work in teams that also requires group discussion.

Alleviating Test Anxiety with Grounding

Panorama Education

Average rating: 4.6/5.0 (25 votes)

Students will be guided through a grounding exercise before beginning an exam in order to alleviate test anxiety and strengthen their confidence. Whe...

Toothbrush Innovations

Panorama Education

Average rating: 5.0/5.0 (2 votes)

Students research the history of the toothbrush and work collaboratively to brainstorm new designs.

Extraterrestrial Invasion

Panorama Education

Average rating: 4.8/5.0 (6 votes)

In this activity, students are tasked with the challenge of describing an element of their life to fictional extraterrestrials who have landed on planet Earth—...

Essay Analysis: Human vs. Machine

Panorama Education

Average rating: 5.0/5.0 (2 votes)

This lesson empowers students to critically evaluate AI-written essays, refining their analytical skills and deepening their understanding of...

Truth vs. Trickery: Spotting Misinformation

Panorama Education

Average rating: 5.0/5.0 (3 votes)

This lesson encourages students to critically assess the information provided by large language models and helps them understand that AI, while...

 **LEARN MORE:** [Access Panorama Playbook](#)



ADDRESSING BARRIERS & BUILDING SUPPORTS



ADDRESSING BARRIERS AND AVERSIONS

Equitable learning environments “respond to the diversity of a school or classroom community, intentionally create rich opportunities for scholar action and reflection, attend to young people’s psychological experience of learning, and develop their feelings of competence, connectedness, and purpose.”⁷

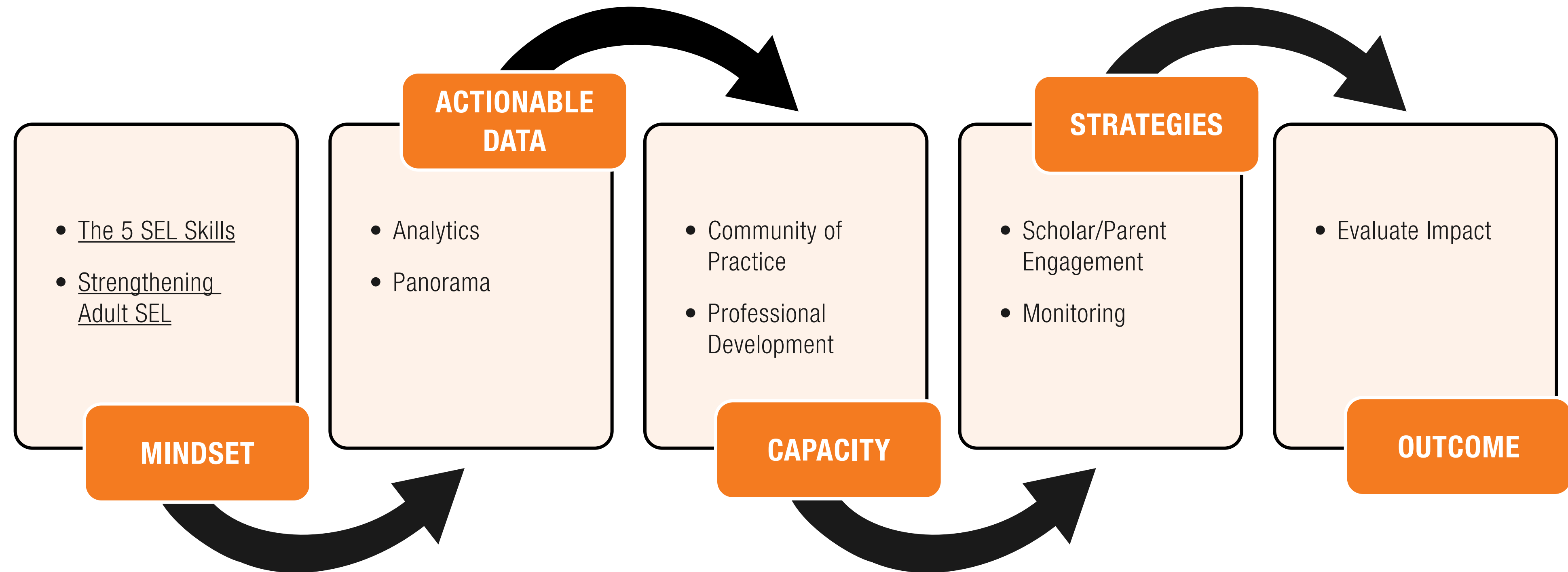
SEL implementation both contributes to and depends upon an equitable learning environment where all students and adults feel respected, supported, and engaged.”⁸

⁷ 2 University of Chicago Consortium on School Research. (2020). *Equitable Learning and Development*.

⁸ Osher, D., & Berg, J. (2017). “School Climate and Social and Emotional Learning: The Integration of Two Approaches.” Edna Bennet Pierce Prevention Research Center, Pennsylvania State University.



THEORY OF CHANGE: EFFECTIVE PRACTICE PATHWAY





ROOT CAUSES OF ABSENCES

BARRIERS	AVERSION	DISENGAGEMENT	MISCONCEPTIONS
• Chronic and acute illness • Family responsibilities or home situation • <u>Trauma</u> • Poor transportation • <u>Housing and food insecurity</u> • <u>Inequitable access to needed services</u> • System involvement • Lack of predictable schedules for learning • Lack of access to tech • Community violence	• <u>Struggling academically and/or behaviorally</u> • <u>Unwelcoming school climate</u> • <u>Social and peer challenges</u> • Anxiety • Biased disciplinary and suspension practices • Undiagnosed disability and/or disability accommodations • Caregivers had negative educational experiences	• Lack of challenging culturally responsive instruction • Bored • <u>No meaningful relationships to adults in school</u> • Lack of academic and behavioral support • Failure to earn credits • Need to work conflicts with being in high school	• Absences are only a problem if they are unexcused • Missing 2 days per month doesn't affect learning • Lose track and underestimate TOTAL absences • <u>Assume students must stay home for any symptom of illness</u> • Attendance only matters in older grades • Suspensions don't count as absence



ALIGN INTERVENTIONS TO REASONS FOR ABSENCES

Reason for Absence	Possible Interventions	Potential Partner
Anxiety	• Enlist trusted messengers to talk with families about health and safety • Meet with school counselor, social worker or psychologist • Offer small groups to teach calming skills	Local pediatricians Cherry Health Behavior Health Clinicians
Disengaged	• Assign a peer group mentor • Create an individualized learning plan • Explore afterschool options (art, music, STEM, etc.) • Offer alternatives for credit recovery	MENTOR Parks & Rec program Boys & Girls Club
Health (Flu / COVID)	• Messaging on how to stay healthy • School nurse educates on preventing spread of flu or Covid • Ensure hygiene supplies available (soap, tissues, hand sanitizer) • Onsite flu and Covid shots	School-based health center Local Clinic / Pediatrician
Transportation Barriers	• Walking School Bus • Free municipal bus passes • Carpools	Parents AmeriCorps program City government



Reminder : Actions Vs. Interventions

An “Action” is something that was done, like sending a letter or making a phone call. It is NOT an intervention.

An “Intervention” is designed to remove a barrier that prevents a student from attending school, changing a behavior, or addressing the situation.



STEPS FOR BUILDING AND LEADING AN EFFECTIVE ATTENDANCE TEAM

 **READ MORE:**
[Attendance Works
Guide with example
agenda for team
development](#)

 **READ MORE:**
[Attendance Works
Self-Assessments](#)

First, identify who should be on team based on attendance data	• Typical team members may include: Family Support Specialist, KSSN Coordinator, Social Worker, Principals, Secretary, ect. • Below are examples of dividing up responsibilities amongst your team: - Principal: Oversee team, set priorities, and ensure accountability. - Family Support Specialist: Coordinate with families and offer direct support. - Secretary: Monitor daily attendance data and identify scholars of concern. <u>View the GRPS Attendance support & Escalation Framework that covers in detail specific roles for each team member.</u>
Use data to determine commonalities among the attendance data	• Examine attendance data by subgroups (grade level, demographics, etc.). • Identify patterns such as: - Specific times of year with high absenteeism. - Common barriers (transportation, health, family issues). - Scholars most impacted
Determine what could individually or as a school community by identifying potential strategies	• Brainstorm targeted and schoolwide interventions. • Strategies may include: - Improved communication with families. - Incentive programs for good attendance. - Mental health or social services referrals. - School climate initiatives to boost engagement.
Evaluate results	• Set measurable goals. • Regularly review attendance data. • Adjust strategies as needed based on what is or isn't working. • Share results with the whole school.

Tips for Teams:

- Create opportunities for everyone to contribute their insights
- Encourage clarifying questions
- Don't just focus on problems but create time to reflect on assets.
- Keep school staff informed and engaged.
- Establish a regular meeting schedule for the school year.



HANDOUTS & TIPS FOR ATTENDANCE TEAMS

Communication Tools & Scripts

- [!\[\]\(31b03e46ee8a80a1f1467b8c03bd76e8_img.jpg\) *Sample Phone Call Scripts*](#)
- [!\[\]\(7d9665ff04f9d2270c38081c6215a724_img.jpg\) *Sample Robocall Script*](#)
- [!\[\]\(7cea648fec4dfc1e99934873e9173b69_img.jpg\) *GRPS Break letters*](#)
- [!\[\]\(48ceb66414885cacc3f139b4fa359213_img.jpg\) *Attendance Works Sample Letters*](#)
- [!\[\]\(01a1fc700f38e6e09ee62e6a9c54d804_img.jpg\) *Communication Script*](#)
- [!\[\]\(833c1865792a2399365d8193854ceab7_img.jpg\) *GRPS “Over 10 days or 5 in a row absent” Letter*](#)
- [!\[\]\(5b4802b5ab32e2afe0a3214e088c55e2_img.jpg\) *Attendance Works Sample Message Materials*](#)

Scholar & Family Support

- [!\[\]\(815df092dd722ee9268ef8e6d0193e3a_img.jpg\) *Scholar Success Plan*](#)
- [!\[\]\(c72edb9626cad660f3a9f5fb0f22a68c_img.jpg\) *K-5 Attendance Tips Handout*](#)
K-5 Tips for scholars and caregivers that can help encourage regular attendance provided by GRPS.
- [!\[\]\(0c564128c6342bd2f601e97f4518828a_img.jpg\) *6-12 Attendance Tips Handout*](#)
6-12 Tips for scholars and caregivers that can help encourage regular attendance provided by GRPS.



FAMILY SUPPORT SPECIALISTS (FSS)

[Family Support Specialists \(FSS\)](#) focus on reducing chronic absenteeism by identifying and removing barriers that are keeping scholars from attending school. FSS works directly with families through home visits and other contacts, providing attendance interventions and resources.

What do we mean by FSS Home Visits?

FSS family visits are voluntary, scheduled opportunities to go to the home (or other neutral location) of a scholar with chronic absence to meet with a parent/family or guardian for the purpose of strengthening the school-family relationship in a positive and relational manner.

The conversation is focused on families' strengths and capabilities, as well as their aspirations for their child. The visitors are there to learn from families and identify additional resources, help address barriers by building on strengths. Ideally, families receive multiple family visits that support building relationships over time.

Helpful Definitions:

- Caring conversations: conversations that takes a strengths based
- approach to build relationships
- [Relationship mapping](#): positive connection to at least one caring adult
- [Scholar voice](#): individual and collective perspective from the scholars point of view within the theme of learning and education



ADDITIONAL RESOURCES



ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

Reading/Articles



[Attendance in Alternative Schools](#)

This is a guide for practitioners and policy advocates to speak with students about attendance in alternative schools.



[Keys to Ending Chronic Absenteeism](#)

An article focusing on how families may be the key to ending chronic absenteeism, a pandemic-era problem that has only gotten worse.



[Attendance is a Family Affair](#)

New research shows how schools can build family engagement as a strategy to reduce absenteeism.



[SEL Questions](#)

50 community building questions for scholars.



[United Way 211](#)

United Way's 2-1-1 connects people to thousands of services across Michigan. Services include food, shelter, utility assistance, childcare, transportation, assistance with disaster recovery, and more. Whoever you are, whatever your needs, 2-1-1 makes it easy to find help for yourself, a neighbor, or a loved one.

Tools/Websites



[Relationship Strategy Bank](#)

an intervention that empowers educators to build authentic relationships with students and increase their sense of belonging



[Dual Capacity-Building Framework](#)

The Dual Capacity-Building Framework for Family-School Partnerships is designed to support the development of family engagement strategies, policies, and programs. The Framework should be seen as a compass, laying out the goals and conditions necessary to chart a path toward effective family engagement efforts that are linked to student achievement and school improvement.



[Parent University](#)

Parent University is a community collaborative to help parents become full partners in their child's education. It offers classes, events, workshops, conferences, leadership training, and mentoring to equip parents for success. Parent University provides all parents opportunities for their children and family to grow and be successful.



[National PTA Family Resources](#)

PTA is a network of millions of families, students, teachers, administrators, and business and community leaders devoted to the educational success of children and the promotion of family engagement in schools.



PREVIOUS GRPS ATTENDANCE RESOURCES



Disruptive Strategies for Change Making

8 pages



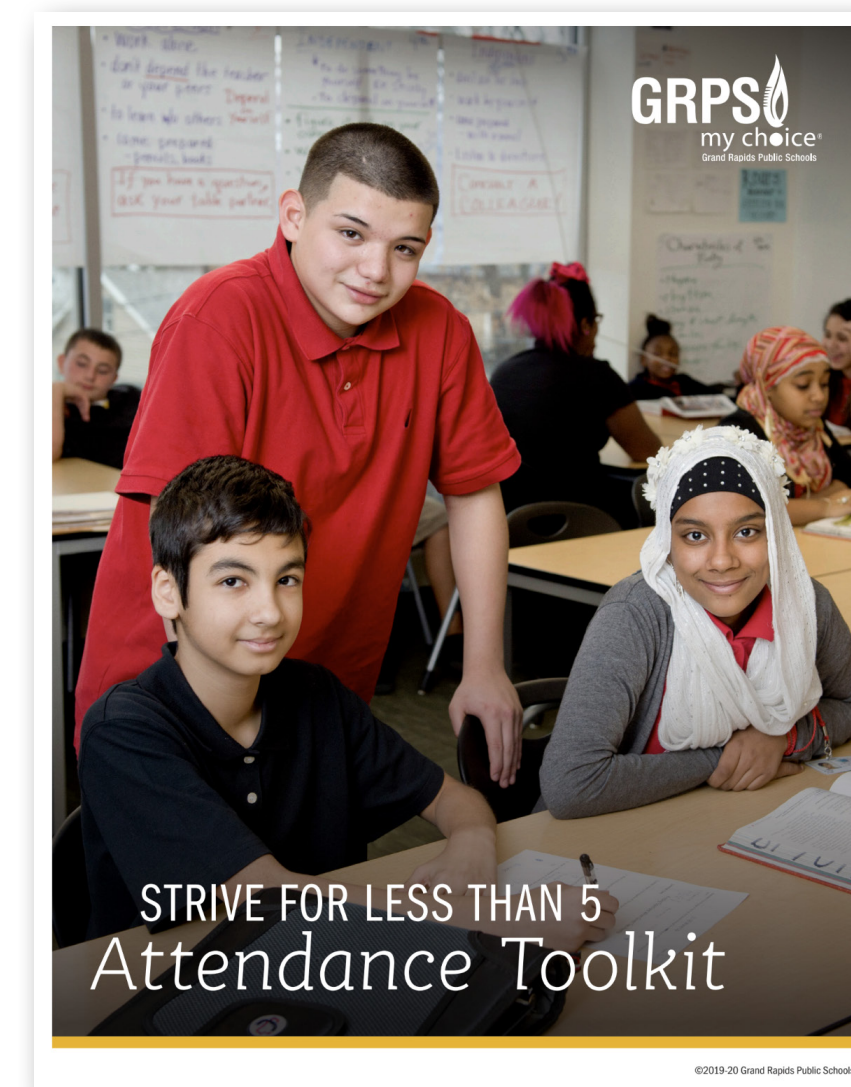
Strive for Less than Five Successful Attendance Strategies

16 pages



Strive for Less than Five Attendance Success Toolkit

43 pages



Strive for Less than Five Attendance Toolkit

56 pages